Pengcheng Lu

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Research Interests

Evaluation of AI systems on cultural judgment; how cultural certification signals (best-seller lists, library records, platform communities) enter language models; cultural analytics; computational social science.

Education

University of Washington, Seattle, WA · Expected June 2027
M.S. in Information Management (Data Science) · GPA 3.91/4.0
Coursework: Data Visualization, Quantitative Research Methods, Data Science
Miami University, Oxford, OH · May 2025
B.S. in Commerce · GPA 3.8/4.0 · Graduated with Distinction · President's List

Honors and Awards

- Larsen Endowed Fellowship, Information School, University of Washington, 2026–2027
- Alternate team (one of two among 67), UW Hollomon Health Innovation Challenge, 2026 (MindBridge)
- 2nd place of 45 teams, Husky Hackathon, University of Washington, 2025
- President's List; Graduated with Distinction, Miami University

Papers Under Review

1. **Pengcheng Lu**. "When BookTok Becomes a Prompt: How Language Models Reorder the Record of a Platform Reading Culture." Under review, ICWSM 2027. Preregistered at OSF.
2. **Pengcheng Lu** and Taixin Zhang. "Verifying Cultural Information about Contemporary Fiction: Language-Model Claims and Public Textual Presence." Under review, CHR 2027.

Working Papers

- **Pengcheng Lu** and Taixin Zhang. "A Shelf and a List: How Two Records of Book Attention Fare When a Language Model Reads Them."

Research Experience

Cultural analytics project led by Professor Melanie Walsh, UW Information School · Feb 2026 – present

- Collected the full record of New York Times best-seller lists from 2008 to 2026 through the NYT Books API.

- Cleaned about 20 million Seattle Public Library checkout records and linked them to listed titles at the work level.
- Analyzing how appearing on a best-seller list relates to public-library borrowing.

Language models and cultural evaluation (independent research), UW · Sep 2025 – present

- Designed controlled experiments on seven open-weight models testing how the wording of a cultural signal changes a model's judgment of a book.
- Measured how language models reproduce a platform reading culture (the Goodreads BookTok shelf) across four model families, with a preregistered analysis plan.
- Practices: preregistration, equivalence testing, construct validation of measures.

MSIM capstone (with Taixin Zhang), UW · Sep 2026 – Jun 2027 · Sponsored by Amazon

- Designing a study of whether the evaluation harness, the software layer that runs a model, changes how source credentials move a language model's judgments of information credibility and book quality.

Capstone research project, Department of Commerce, Miami University · Spring 2025
Supervisor: Dr. Tom Mays

- Designed and ran a within-subject pilot experiment (21 participants) testing whether labeling ads as AI-generated changes Gen Z viewers' attention, interest, desire and action; found no reliable average effect.
- Report co-written with Dr. Mays: "Visual Ads in the Age of AI: How Gen Z's Attitudes Shape Ad Effectiveness."

Teaching

Reader, IMT 550 B: Policy and Ethics in Information Management, UW Information School · Summer 2026
Instructor: Mark Dennis Robinson. Graded weekly work and wrote feedback for 23 students; handled student communication and accommodations with the instructor.

Service

Reviewer, ICWSM 2027 (two papers)

Professional Experience

Huayu Electronics, Financial Analysis Specialist, Chengdu, China · May 2024 – Aug 2024
Mapped production workflows and ran in-house versus outsourcing scenario analyses.
China Tower, Market Analysis Intern, Chengdu, China · May 2022 – Aug 2022
Audited more than 1 million transaction records and standardized firm-level fields across systems.

Skills

Programming: Python (Polars, pandas, RapidFuzz), SQL, Stata
Research methods: experimental design, preregistration, equivalence testing, regression, entity resolution
AI evaluation: running and auditing open-weight language models
Visualization: p5.js, Tableau, Matplotlib, Figma
Languages: Chinese (native), English